



Incident Handler's Journal

Date: 2026-07-14	Entry: Journal Entry #1
Description	Documenting a cybersecurity incident.
Tool(s) used	None.
The 5 W's	• Who – A group of unethical hackers • What – A ransomware security incident • When – Tuesday 9:00am • Where – A small U.S. health care clinic • Why – The incident occurred following an email sent by malicious actors with a downloadable attachment citing a successful phishing attack. Once the attachment was downloaded, ransomware was deployed encrypting company files. The malicious actors' motivations appear to be financial following a detailed ransom note demanding a large sum of money in exchange for an encryption key.
Additional notes	Can the ransomware be removed or decrypted without paying the ransom? Can a search through files detail what information has been encrypted (i.e.: personal PII of clients, doctor notes, billing information, etc.)?

Date: 2026-07-20	Entry: Journal Entry #2
Description	Analyzing a packet capture file. (walk-through activity)
Tool(s) used	Wireshark.
The 5 W's	Capture the 5 W's of an incident. • Who – none • What – none • When – none • Where – none • Why – none
Additional notes	It is interesting to use Wireshark in this scenario to understand how to analyze and assess packet capture files and understanding network activity/traffic.

Date: Record the date of the journal entry.	Entry: Journal Entry #3
Description	Investigation into a suspicious file hash.
Tool(s) used	VirusTotal.
The 5 W's	Capture the 5 W's of an incident. • Who – A malicious actor (unknown at time of information gathering) • What – A phishing email sent to an employee containing a trojan virus SHA-256 file hash: 54e6ea47eb04634d3e87fd7787e2136ccfbcc80ade34f246a12cf93bab527f6b • When – 13:20:00 • Where – An employee's device in a finance company • Why – The employee downloaded and executed a malicious file attached via email, initiating the trojan virus onto the network.
Additional notes	1 - What was within the content of the email that prompted the employee to download the file? 2 - Following this event, it is imperative to consider a security training for employees to understand the severity of opening suspicious emails that make it through the IDS system in place and the protocols to report these incidents rather than becoming events.

Date: Record the date of the journal entry.	Entry: Journal Entry #4
Description	Packet capture.
Tool(s) used	TCPdump (walkthrough activity).
The 5 W's	Capture the 5 W's of an incident. • Who – none • What – none • When – none • Where – none • Why – none
Additional notes	Enjoying continued use of command-line tools and applying it to packet captures and network traffic. I struggled with syntax of command lines but managed to use support tools to understand how to overcome my errors and the specific codes needed to be written to generate the capture.

Reflections/Notes: Record additional notes.

1. Were there any specific activities that were challenging for you? Why or why not?

I found the activities rather straightforward and useful to understand more about the cybersecurity tools at the disposal of security analysts when investigating, documenting, and resolving incidents. However, the command-line interface is still the most interesting and most difficult to understand having and adjusting my understanding of having to be exact in my prompts led to some challenges.

2. Has your understanding of incident detection and response changed after taking this course?

Yes, my understanding of incident detection and response has evolved from knowing virtually nothing to a grounded understanding on *how* analysts go about resolving these issues. While it seems straightforward with the activities, I am concerned that in the practical field with time as a stressor, my abilities will be tested but trust my quick decision making and following of playbooks to ensure that success is the #1 outcome.